

Supporting Vulnerable Households to Reconstruct: Learning from Field Experience

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Dhokaima Café, Patan

Participants: NSET, NRA, Mott MacDonald/Purnima, World Bank, SwissContact, CRS, Lutheran World Relief, Helvetas, Save the Children, Scott Wilson Nepal, JICA, People in Need, Japanese Red Cross Society, Mercy Corps, Anthropology TU, American Red Cross, Practical Action, Feminist Dalit Organisation, Build Change, HSI, CAN, IDE-Nepal, BBC Media Action, and UNDP.

Introduction

During the last meeting of the [HRRP's Vulnerable Support Working Group \(VSWG\) on 2 July](#), it was agreed that there is a need to bring together the experiences of partners that have field experience supporting vulnerable households to guide scale up of this support. This session was organised based on this, with the objective of providing an opportunity to learn what worked well, what didn't work well, and what should be considered moving forward.

6 Partner Organisations (POs) presented their experience during the event; Save the Children, JICA, NSET, CARE Nepal, Feminist Dalit Organisation (FEDO), and UNDP.

Save the Children – [Shelter Recovery Support, Practice in Nepal](#)

Save the Children was the first organisation to have a tri-partite agreement with the NRA. The agreement was for construction of 1,800 HHs, using conditional cash grant, across four districts; Gorkha, Sindhupalchowk, Nuwakot, and Dolakha. HHs were selected as per the provisions in the NGO mobilisation guideline and all are from vulnerable groups:

- 1,000 HHs (56%) are from extremely poor families
- 100 families have family members with disabilities
- 14% of families are headed by single women
- 6 families are headed by children (supported by close relatives)

The support provided to each household included the GoN housing reconstruction grant of 300,000 NPRs, technical assistance for construction (structural analysis, supervision, guidance for correction), developed 5 prototype designs additional to 17 designs in the DUDBC design catalogue volume 1, support for release of grants (coordination with GoN for visit and verification, filling up the checklists, follow up with Bank, GoN agency for tranche release), and provision of top-ups to cover transport, material, or labour costs.

Roving / mobile masons (1/20 vulnerable HHs) were provided to support with supervision on site. Shelter construction groups were also formed to monitor the reconstruction rate and provide technical support if needed. Group purchasing of construction materials saved costs for households.

To minimise conflict, community engagement and participation of households and local GoN from the beginning is important. The owner driven approach is suitable in general, but the most vulnerable households should be supported differently depending on their need and capabilities. Support with small scale community works helped to complete the shelter on time (e.g. road clearance, water supply).

JICA – [Community Mobilisation Program for Vulnerable Beneficiaries](#)

The JICA programme is supporting 56,087 households across 2 districts; Sindhupalchowk and Gorkha. 885 of these households were included in the vulnerable list prepared by the NRA, and 44.2% of them have already received the third tranche of the housing reconstruction grant. JICA have found that there is a significant gap between the number of non-vulnerable households that have received the second and third tranches, and the rate at which vulnerable households have received these tranches.

Through the Community Mobilisation Programme (CMP) JICA is supporting coordination between local authorities and NRA, Building DLPIU staff with a particular focus on targeted support for vulnerable households and coordinating efforts to support these households. Community discussions on specific issues are also conducted. Topics covered include why households have not been able to start reconstruction (conducted only with those households), non-compliances (conducted only with households whose homes require corrections), etc. Technical support from mobile masons, or in some cases mobile masons have provided direct labour support for vulnerable households. They have also engaged the Community Based Reconstruction Committee (CBRC) to provide support to vulnerable households with the CBRC required to allocate a certain amount of time for this daily.

These activities have seen a dramatic increase in construction rate, and in compliance. The impact for vulnerable households is particularly positive as there are more targeted initiatives to support them in a variety of ways, and the issue specific community discussions provide a forum where groups facing specific challenges can raise their concerns and work with the CBRC, local authorities, and technical staff to come up with ways to address them.

NSET – [Baliyo Ghar Programme](#)

The Baliyo Ghar programme has supported 1404 HHs from the NRA vulnerable list; 46% single women, 48% senior citizen, 4% PWD, and 2% children. The local authorities have suggested some additional households that are considered vulnerable and should be added to the NRA list of vulnerable households.

Under Baliyo Ghar, vulnerable HHs are supported with continuous technical support through a blanket approach model. A technical resource centre provides the focal point for the support, with technical assistance teams operating at household level.

There is a need for a more targeted support package for vulnerable households and a different approach for the tranche disbursement system should be considered for vulnerable households. Continuous technical support is key to helping vulnerable households progress through the reconstruction process. The vulnerable criteria should be more dynamic in order to ensure that the needs of truly vulnerable households are not missed because of rigid criteria.

CARE Nepal – [Stronger communities and safer habitat: Promoting self-recovery](#)

Started working in Gorkha, Dhading, and Sindhupalchowk following NRA's NGO mobilisation guideline criteria for support to vulnerable households. Developed vulnerable selection criteria for the beneficiary selection in addition to NRA's criteria and identified 507 vulnerable households to support.

CARE Nepal formed alliances of skilled masons, carpenters, and community mobilisers under the local authorities and mobilised these alliances as 'shelter champions' or 'shelter brigades'. Continuous socio-technical assistance support was provided to get the household up to plinth level and facilitate access to the second tranche. The local authorities were fully engaged to make it more accountable.

UNDP – [Resilient Communities through Building Back Better](#)

Supporting 55,260 households across Dolakha and Sindhupalchowk districts. Targeting the most at risk households for the sociotechnical facilitation through reconstruction action plan and building necessary capacities.

VDCs undertake reconstruction in accordance with the Reconstruction Action Plan (RAP) through an inclusive process. Local masons trained through on-the-job training (OJT) by constructing Technology Demonstration Houses (TDHs) for most vulnerable households. Safer Construction Clinics and Hardware Shops established to support the communities to build back better through supply of affordable construction materials. Most-at-risk house-owners received reconstruction grant (in-kind construction material support worth 50,000 NPRs) to build safer disaster resilient houses. They were all technically supported as well. Resilience Fund to support the vulnerable HHs (Revolving funds have been established in Aarughat, Dharche and Sahid Lakhan GPs in Gorkha). Implemented 'Awas Nirman Saathi' – mobilising trained masons for door to door support for households.

House-owners faced challenges for tranche-release, for vulnerable HHs it's even more challenging. Retention of trained artisans in reconstruction was a challenge because of their higher-aspiration. Female trainees were less accepted as capable artisans due to socio-political constraint. Vulnerable groups need support for an extended period of time, even after receiving skill enhancement and entrepreneurship training.

Feminist Dalit Organisation (FEDO) – [Supporting Earthquake affected Dalit Families to increase access for them to the reconstruction](#)

FEDO supported earthquake affected families in the immediate earthquake response in collaboration and coordination with national and international agencies and support generated through its network. A total of 65 temporary shelters were built in Kavre and Kathmandu to accommodate more than 1,450 earthquake affected people. Supported in constructing 461 toilets for earthquake affected Dalit households in Boch and Sunkhani VDC of Dolakha and Manthali and Ramechhap Municipality of Ramechhap district.

Though they do not have the direct reconstruction support to the earthquake affected communities but they are continuously working in policy lobbying and awareness creation to increase the access of Dalit communities in the reconstruction program so that they could participate and get benefit from the reconstruction campaign of the country. Besides FEDO is also doing the research and study in the gap of service delivery in the post-earthquake reconstruction program. Promotion and creation of economic/livelihood opportunities to the earthquake affected population is also one of the major activity of FEDO.

NRA – Ms. Archana Tamang, GESI Advisor

Ms. Tamang urged all POs to ensure better coordination between different sectors to increase the speed of the reconstruction and to standardise the quality of the reconstruction so that NRA could achieve the envisioned progress within the given time.

She also focused on the need for livelihood support to vulnerable HHs so that they can continue living their life in more sustainable ways after the reconstruction is completed. Clarifying the criteria used to identify the NRA's list of vulnerable households, Ms. Tamang stated that the 4 criteria were segregated from 116 different points in vulnerability index so that the NRA could focus support to the neediest first.

She finally requested all the partners that though the published vulnerable list is not complete and have different concerns and challenges but once we start to work on supporting them then only we can reach the field and most needy so that the POs can advocate and inform the NRA to reach more population within the given mandate period.

Discussion and Q&A

Q: What is the role of Partner Organisations (POs) in support to vulnerable households?

A: As per Save the Children's field level experience, forming a reconstruction support group and nominating one or more individual for the purchasing, transporting and supply of the materials for the vulnerable is effective way to support reconstruction along with the continuous socio-technical support.

Q: In relation to NSET's presentation, are the 41% of population that are not constructing at all from the NRA's vulnerable list and has there been any analysis on why they are lagging behind?

A: Yes, these 41% population are from the NRA vulnerable list. NSET has not done any detail analysis as such but based on the discussion with these population the answers received were mostly generic like lack of fund, non-availability of the other supporting family members to support construction, etc.

Q: Why did CARE Nepal develop different criteria for the selection of vulnerable HHs?

A: Care Nepal has developed the vulnerable identification criteria to prioritise among those listed as vulnerable by the NRA. In addition, the selection of the vulnerable beneficiary is done with the verification of NRA list by the local GoN.

Q: How did CARE Nepal form the mason alliances?

A: The masons who have received trainings and are actively working in the reconstruction are organized in a group so that they can be deployed to the HHs on a needs basis.

Q: Has CARE Nepal faced any socio-political pressure at local level to add particular households to the vulnerable list?

A: They have come across such situation in some level but before adding to the list, Care Nepal includes all political, social actors in one place for the discussion and verification then only if the recommended HHs are genuinely vulnerable then only add in the list.

Q: In most of the cases female masons are not accepted well by society, what action is UNDP taking in relation to this?

A: UNDP has an inclusive approach and includes the female masons as part of the reconstruction process to capacitate them and in most cases in the later parts the female mason trainee becomes supervisor motivating them to work in community.

Q: What criteria does UNDP use to establish the Safer Construction Clinics? What is the cost effectiveness?

A: Basically, the geographical area and the necessity of these types of clinics are the major deciding factors for establishment. The required resource materials and the cost is identified based on the house typology and size. Whenever the HHs want to build a particular type of house then they will be given the clear idea about the total cost which will help them to decide accordingly.

Mr. Yub Raj Basnet stated that reconstruction actors should also focus on analysing the reasons why some people are still lagging behind in the reconstruction process. We have already understood that supporting the vulnerable is a long process but in many cases the POs can't complete the activity from start to end in supporting the vulnerable. The different layers of vulnerability need to be explored and interlinked. The learnings from the PO's project have not been captured well like why the vulnerable are not getting enough support? Why the reconstruction speed is slow and many more.

Q: How do communities perceive the deadlines for tranche disbursement? Are there any examples of good ways to motivate households to build within the deadlines?

A: BBC Media Action shared that the deadlines have been found to cause a lot of concern and stress for earthquake affected families and there is a lot of confusion around the implications of missing the deadlines. There are many rumours about a 'blacklist' and potential loss of social security if the deadlines are not met. There are also rumours that children of families that do not meet the deadlines will not be able to get citizenship. HRRP shared that the platform has been advocating for an extension to the deadlines for the next two building seasons to allow a reasonable timeframe for people to reconstruct their homes.